



Early childhood education contingencies for sustaining learning during school closures: Lessons from preschool remote education home visits in Indonesia during the COVID-19 pandemic

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ABSTRACT

Maintaining kindergarten education amid emergency situations is difficult. The COVID-19 pandemic highlighted the difficulties faced by early childhood education institutions in ensuring that children continue education despite school closures and prolonged social isolation. The transition from in-classroom learning to remote learning, which was mostly online for older age groups, was especially complicated for younger pupils due to their nature and limited family resources. In contrast, numerous kindergartens in Indonesia initiated home visit programs that enabled children to learn face-to-face with their teachers and peers during the school closure periods. The purpose of this study was to examine how the home visit program for early childhood education was implemented and how teachers and parents viewed this emergency alternative to online learning. A qualitative case study was employed as a method of inquiry. Nine parents and four teachers from a single kindergarten in South Tangerang, a suburb of Jakarta, participated in this study. The data revealed the home visit program's implementation involved the following measures: dividing children into small groups, a teacher visiting each group's assigned home once or twice per week for 45–90 min, enforcing health measures, and giving daily activities for students to complete with their parents. Teachers stated that the home visit program was helpful but had significant faults. Among the benefits were the following: It helped children comprehend learning materials, piqued their interest, and served as a possible alternative due to a family's lack of resources such as electricity, internet connectivity and quota, educators' competency in implementing online learning, and parents limited or unavailable devices. Meanwhile, some disadvantages of home visits included the following: Parents felt obligated to entertain their children's teachers and peers, some students were unable to study due to distance, additional time and energy was spent on media preparation and learning activities, and the risk of exposure to COVID-19 was increased. In the future, unexpected health hazards or other situations may occur. These findings indicate the need for early childhood education institutions to be more prepared, develop a strategy and adjust their instructional approaches to respond rapidly to changing circumstances when required.

1. Introduction

The COVID-19 outbreak triggered an unprecedented educational crisis (Grek & Landri, 2021). In countries where the pandemic had a significant impact, the policy of school closure was mandated (Lennox et al., 2021). School closures aim to reduce the number of infected students in schools, to reduce transmission from schoolchildren to children outside of school, and, more generally, to monitor the spread of infection until additional intervention methods (such as vaccinations) are readily available or until environmental factors, such as temperature and humidity, reduce transmission (Auger et al., 2020; Azevedo et al.,

2021; Briscese et al., 2020).

Schools are crucial for children's overall well-being, providing a structured environment that supports physical activity, social and emotional skill development, and essential services such as health care, food distribution, and child protection (Aliyar et al., 2015; García Bacete et al., 2014; Mayurasakorn et al., 2020; Sari, 2019; Wang & Fawzi, 2020; Zimmo et al., 2017). Establishing a sense of normalcy through routine is vital for young children's ability to function well (Höjer & Johansson, 2013; Vernberg et al., 2016). Therefore, adaptive strategies to resume in-person schooling are essential for their development and well-being (Cheung et al., 2022).

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1.1. Pandemic challenges in early childhood education

In Indonesia, nationwide school closures affected 60.2 million students and 2.3 million educators across 425,451 educational institutions, from early childhood education to higher education (Dikti, 2018; Ministry of Education and Culture, 2019, 2020b, 2020c, 2020a, 2020d). The closures, which began in March 2020, lasted for a year and a half, with schools fully reopening only in the July 2022 semester.

Early childhood education schools were particularly unprepared for distance learning. In response, various strategies were employed worldwide. In Turkey, teachers primarily used games, art activities, and home experiments (Duran, 2021). In the United States, some kindergartens transformed schooling into home activities with parental involvement (Stites et al., 2021). However, many preschools worldwide, including those in Hong Kong, Greece, Palestine, Italy, and Jordan, predominantly relied on online learning methods supported by advanced technology (Abu-Rabba et al., 2021; Ahmad & Zabadi, 2020; Foti, 2020; Lau & Lee, 2021; Panesi et al., 2021).

In Indonesia, preschools shifted to online education, using platforms like WhatsApp for communication and video conferences (Rahiem & Perdana, 2022; Riadil et al., 2020). Despite these efforts, online learning posed significant challenges for young children, who often struggled to adapt to remote schooling (Dong et al., 2020; Kim, 2020). Although some young children are familiar with digital technology (Chaudron et al., 2015; Palaoligou, 2016), the presence of a teacher or other adult was crucial for effective learning (Commodari, 2013; DeMulder et al., 2000). Moreover, access to technology was a persistent barrier for many families (Rahiem, 2021). Therefore, online learning may not be the best option for kindergarteners due to low levels of engagement among children, a lack of knowledge and skills for virtual instruction, and technological access issues. (Ford et al., 2021).

Recognizing the limitations of online learning, teachers sought minimally or non-technological alternatives. Worksheet-based learning emerged as a common approach, with parents collecting and returning assignments weekly (Dayal & Tiko, 2020; Setyowahyudi & Ferdiyanti, 2020). However, this method also placed a significant burden on parents, who often felt overwhelmed by the responsibility of assisting with their children's education (Mufaziah & Fauziah, 2020; Winarti et al., 2021).

Some parents complained that they did not understand the subject, others did not know how to teach it, and the remainder remarked that they lacked the spare time required to help their children learn, owing to housework and employment. Parents were also upset that they had paid for their children's education, but still had to educate them.

To address these challenges, home visits became a viable alternative, particularly in frontier, remote, and disadvantaged areas. Teachers conducted home visits to provide direct support to students, combined with WhatsApp communication and video instruction (Ibda & Laeli, 2021; Mokoginta & Nurdiani, 2020; Mulyaningsih & Iskandar, 2021; Nirmala & Annuar, 2020). The Indonesian government even regarded home visits as a viable alternative to in-school instruction during the pandemic, especially for kindergarten and elementary children (Sholeh, 2021; Suhendro, 2020).

Furthermore, there is a significant enrollment disparity between public and private kindergartens in Indonesia. While exact figures vary, private kindergartens tend to have more resources and flexibility in implementing diverse learning strategies compared to public institutions, which often face more significant resource constraints. This disparity was highlighted during the pandemic as private kindergartens were generally better equipped to switch to online and hybrid models of learning.

1.2. A conceptual framework

With the COVID-19 situation better managed and students returning to school, it is crucial to evaluate previous strategies and seek more

effective alternative learning methods for future crises. This study explores kindergarten teachers' and parents' insights and experiences with home visits in early childhood education. Home visits were favored during the pandemic for their ability to provide immediate support, motivate students, and gather valuable information about children's learning styles and challenges (Makmun, 2021; Sholeh, 2021). This analysis aims to enhance the effectiveness and responsiveness of home-visit programs for emergency learning, guided by a conceptual framework that assesses the advantages and disadvantages of this approach.

2. Materials and methods

This study employed a qualitative case study methodology to conduct an in-depth examination of the home visit program as a strategy for early childhood education during the COVID-19 pandemic. The focus was on one kindergarten, XYZ, in South Tangerang, Banten. (Kindergarten identity concealed). This approach was chosen because case study research allows for a thorough understanding of contemporary phenomena within their real-world context, particularly when the boundaries between phenomenon and context are not clearly defined (Rashid et al., 2019; Yin, 2018).

2.1. Rationale for case study approach and sampling strategy

The decision to conduct the study at only one school, Kindergarten XYZ, was deliberate. Conducting the study in a single school enabled the researcher to gain a deep and nuanced understanding of the specific context and dynamics at play. This choice allowed for a focused examination of the home visit program's implementation and its impacts during the pandemic. The implications of this choice include a detailed exploration of the phenomena but also a limitation in generalizability to other settings.

A purposive sampling strategy was employed to select participants who could provide rich, relevant, and diverse perspectives on the home visit program. Thirteen participants, including educational context, making it impossible to reopen schools for the new academic year in July 2021. Consequently, in-person school attendance was postponed until July 2022.

Data collection methods included in-depth interviews, observations, and document analysis. Thirteen participants were interviewed: four teachers and nine parents. All participants were female, as all teachers at the kindergarten are female, and only mothers were willing to participate.

The participants' demographic information is detailed in Table 1. The criteria for selecting participants included their direct involvement with the kindergarten and the home visit program. Teachers needed to be employed at Kindergarten XYZ, and parents needed to have children aged 4 to 7 attending the school. Consent forms and informational sheets were provided to ensure participants were fully informed and their anonymity protected.

All Kindergarten XYZ teachers expressed their consent to be a part of the study. Two teachers, including the principal, have bachelor's degrees in early childhood education, while two teachers have diplomas in education. The kindergarten had 39 pupils enrolled for the 2020/21 academic year, spread across four classes. Parents' ages ranged from 22 to 38 years. Among the mothers, two were stay-at-home moms, two worked for the government, two were teachers, one was a cashier at a department store, and two were business owners. (Table 1. Demographic information of participants).

To protect the anonymity of participants and the kindergarten, the researcher concealed their identities. Participants were given consent forms and informational sheets, ensuring they were fully informed about the study and could withdraw at any time. Research protocols and proposals were submitted to the university's Center for Research and Publications, and study clearances were obtained before the research began.

Table 1
Demographic information of participants.

No	Status	Acronym	Age	Gender	Occupation	Last Education
	Teacher	GA1	28	Female	Teacher	Bachelor of Early Childhood Education
		GA2	34	Female	Teacher	Diploma of Education
		GB1	38	Female	Teacher	Diploma of Education
		GB2	42	Female	Teacher	Bachelor of Early Childhood Education
	Parent	OA1	22	Female	Stay-at-home mom	Senior high school Diploma
		OA2	27	Female	Government employee	Diploma
		OA3	25	Female	Teacher	Diploma in Education
		OB1	32	Female	Business owner	Senior high school Diploma
		OB2	38	Female	Business owner	Diploma
		OB3	30	Female	Government employee	Bachelor of Arts
		OB4	29	Female	Cashier	Senior high school
		OB5	35	Female	Stay-at-home mom	Junior high school
		OB6	24	Female	Teacher	Bachelor of Education

Teachers were interviewed at the school while preparing classroom materials, and parents were interviewed during home visits. Each semi-structured interview lasted between 30 and 40 min. The researcher transcribed the interviews, recorded observation memos, and classified documents according to their type. Data collection and analysis were concurrent processes, each informing and influencing the other (Tetnowski, 2015). The researcher ensured that the case study was planned and executed meticulously, integrating data collection and analysis throughout the process.

2.2. Data analysis

The researcher utilized explanation building, one of Yin's five essential analytic techniques for case studies (Yin, 2009). This method involves formulating initial theoretical propositions and continuously refining them through comparison with empirical data. The iterative nature of this process helps identify causal relationships and understand how and why certain phenomena occur.

Construct validity was ensured through triangulation of multiple data sources, including interviews, observations, and documents. Member checks were conducted to enhance internal validity, with interview transcripts reviewed and clarified by participants. Excerpts from the transcripts were included in the research report to support the study's conclusions. To ensure reliability, the researcher maintained detailed study protocols and databases containing all collected and analyzed data.

3. Results & Discussion

3.1. Methods used to carry out the home visit program

During the COVID-19 pandemic, when schools were closed, alternative educational methods like the home visit program became essential, particularly in Indonesia, where many families lacked internet access and electronic devices. The government recommended the home visit program as a feasible alternative for early and primary education.

The data revealed that the home visit program was implemented in the following ways: by dividing children into small groups, visiting each small group's designated house once or twice a week for 45 min to two hours per visit, reducing class hours while retaining the beginning, main, and closing aspects of the session, enforcing strict health measures during the meeting and assigning daily assignments for the children to complete with their parents following the visit.

3.2. The teachers divided children who lived nearby into groups of three to five

Cooperative learning, in which students work in groups, has been widely recognized as a pedagogical strategy that facilitates socialization and learning among students from kindergarten through to college (Gillies, 2014). Cooperative learning strengthens skills in reading and writing, scientific comprehension, mathematical problem-solving, and critical thinking, and reasoning (Farzaneh & Nejadansari, 2014). Bertucci et al. (Bertucci et al., 2016) found that student performance improved when they worked in groups of two or four compared to working alone, when they had the support of their peers and also felt more confident in their own abilities. The children in the home visit program implemented by Kindergarten XYZ were likewise divided into groups of three to five children who lived nearby. In addition to convenience, the educational benefits of pupils studying in smaller groups have become a significant factor in adopting this alternative teaching strategy.

GA1 stated that she divided her fourteen students into four groups based on their proximity to one another. "There were four groups in my class, and in each group all of the children lived in the same neighborhood, less than a kilometer away from each other." (GA1/Teacher/Interview/Observation). OB6 said her K2-grade daughter studied with a group of three girls and two boys who lived nearby:

My daughter belonged to group C. I was informed that there were other groups. My daughter was one of three girls and two boys in her group. I know their parents, as we all live in the same neighborhood. I walked to her friend's house, which is 400 m from ours. Well, sometimes I would ride a motorcycle. It depends. It was not too far. (OB6/Parent/Interview)

3.3. For each group of students, the teachers devised a visit plan

Anticipating a protracted crisis, the Minister of Education and Culture of the Republic of Indonesia enacted regulation No. 719/P/2020 to implement the COVID-19 emergency curriculum. The regulation mandates that the school cuts meeting times, alters teaching strategies, and simplifies lesson plans (Handayani & Muliastri, 2021; Monica & Yaswinda, 2021; Wati, 2015). The teacher has complete authority over the simplified lesson plan. The objective of simplifying the lesson plan is to ensure that it can be understood by the parents who will study with their children at home. A simplified lesson plan is restricted to one or two pages and contains the following components: 1) program identification; 2) development aspect; (3) teacher assignment; and (4) evaluation and report (Muhlisoh, 2021). As a result of the shift in teaching methods, the Kindergarten XYZ teacher devised a strategy, a central tenet of which was to schedule visits once or twice a week and then determine the agenda for each session.

GA1 and GA2, who teach K1, visited each group once per week. "Each group was visited once a week. I made home visits daily, Monday through to Thursday, for each group." (GA1/Teacher/Interview/Observation). However, GB1 and GB2, who teach K2, visited each group twice per week, "Every Monday and Wednesday I met with groups A and B. On Tuesdays and Thursdays, I met with groups C and D." (GB2/Teacher/Interview/Observation). Every visit lasted between 45 and 90 min. "So, the children will meet with me twice weekly for one to two hours per visit." (GB1/Teacher/Interview).

3.4. The class differed from a typical class since it was abbreviated, but the beginning, main, and closing sections of the sessions remained

GB1 explained how she arranged her class: "During the home visit program, we did things that were similar to regular school, but not the same. I began by explaining the topic to the children. In the main session we sang, danced, colored, and drew together. At the end of class, I had everyone sit in a circle and say a prayer together." (GB1/Teacher/Interview). When learning is conducted in-person at school, students attend 2 to 3 h per day for pre-kindergarten and 3 to 4 h per day for kindergarten. GA2 addressed the distinction between classes with home visits during a pandemic and typical classes.

During the home visit program, the class gets dismissed earlier than usual. Typically, the day would begin with children playing freely in the playground, followed by morning greetings with teachers in front of the class and pupils forming lines to enter the classroom. After reciting the prayer, I introduced the lesson, discussed the topic, and described the day's activities. Then, we began with class activities, including counting, letter recognition, drawing, dancing, singing, puzzles, cutting and pasting, paper rolling, and storytelling. Later, I summarized the day's lecture, and the class recited the closing prayer. Children had a class just once or twice per week and for very brief periods. There was an introduction, the main lesson, and a conclusion, although not all class rituals were performed. There were no lineups to enter the house, like there were at kindergarten before we entered the class. We sat on the floor because there was no table; at school, we sat on chairs with a table in front of us. Aside from that, there was no time for a snack. During in-person sessions, proper eating habits were often taught to children during snack time, but not during home visits. (GA2/Teacher/Interview)

3.5. The teachers emphasized that children participating in the home visit program must follow health measures

OA1 stated she ensured children adhered to health protocols. "They should wear masks or face shields and wash their hands or use hand sanitizer." (GA1/Teacher/Interview). Similar sentiments were expressed by GB2. "This study visit is an option, but we must not be irresponsible. Health precautions should be enforced. However, it is difficult to keep young children wearing a mask." (GB2/Teacher/Interview). OB3 revealed how she prepared her son to participate in the home visit program: "I instructed my son to wear a mask, maintain a safe distance, refrain from eating during the visit, and wash his hands both before and after the session." (OB3/Parent/Interview).

3.6. Following the home visit, teachers provide daily assignments for children to do with their parents at home

GB1 described how she meticulously prepared children's home follow-up activities. "I created daily lesson plans and assignments for the children's home study and shared them with their parents. The framework of the lesson plans was so basic that parents are able to comply with them, however I need to describe in detail the tasks that must be done. The assignments are for one to two days, when the teacher was not conducting a home visit. They served as class substitutes." (GB1/Teacher/Interview). OB4 explained that the teacher provided activities for children to do at home with parents. "Yes, after the visit, the teacher will call us and tell us what to do with the kids at home when there isn't a home visit. We turned in our finished homework on Fridays. The teachers then looked over the work, and we got their comments on Mondays." (OB4/Parent/Interview/Observation).

3.7. The advantages and disadvantages of the home-visit program

Some earlier studies identified the issues with COVID-19 online

learning for early childhood education, namely the lack of such learning for children's social-emotional development and the fact that online learning is not ideal for young children due to their age and inability to maintain their focus on the lessons (Sonnenschein & Stites, 2021; Stites et al., 2021b). However, this strategy is also not completely effective; there are both drawbacks and benefits. Among the advantages were the following: It assisted children in comprehending learning materials, piqued their interest, and served as a potential alternative due to a family's lack of access to resources such as technological devices, electricity, internet access and internet quotas, educators' competency in implementing online learning, and parents limited or limited capacity to use devices. Meanwhile, some of the disadvantages of home visits that made them undesirable or necessitated adjustments included the following: It was inconvenient for parents because they felt obliged to entertain teachers and other children, and they were exhausted since they had to teach their children and assist them with their homework, some students were unable to study due to the home visit location being too far away, more media preparation and learning activities were required, more time and energy was spent, and the risk of exposure to COVID-19 was increased.

3.8. The advantages of the home visit program

3.8.1. The home visit program helped children understand what they were learning

To properly learn, children need the guidance of an adult to aid in their intellectual and practical development. Adults pay attention to the child, provide for their needs, play with them, help them learn, and then step back to let them explore independently. Personal connections are vital for young children to learn well, yet they are practically impossible to create through online instruction. Parents are now expected to be involved in the learning of their children. They lacked the essential knowledge and competence to teach young children, and many were too distracted with their own work to spend much attention on it. Parents argued that their children learned better from their teachers than from them; therefore, the home visit program let children learn with their teachers when they could not attend school because of COVID-19 social restrictions. According to OB1, her daughter was highly indulged when studying with her. She frequently wanted to avoid completing the work.

I'd rather have my daughter do her schoolwork alongside her teacher. She doesn't hear what I say. A home visit is good. She could work with her teacher and other students. The teachers could instruct them more effectively, help the kids understand the lesson and then complete their homework. (OB1/Parent/Interview)

3.8.2. The home visit program sparked the children's interest in learning and continuing learning

OB5 said that her son was more willing to study when the teacher came to their house to study with him and his friends. "My son kept asking me when his teacher would come. He was looking for his friends. He loves exploring new things with his friends." (OB5/Parent/Interview) OB2 stated that her daughter's eagerness to learn resulted from her meeting with her pals. She was dissatisfied that she could not attend school and lacked the motivation to complete her schoolwork, but on the day of the home visit, she got eager to complete her homework. "She would get up early and be delighted to go to her classmate's house to meet her teacher and friends. I could tell that she was looking forward to studying with them." (OB2/Parent/Interview).

3.8.3. The home visit program was a good alternative because some families did not have electricity, internet access, or enough internet quota

Home visits allow children with limited or no access to electricity and the internet to study without using the technical equipment that requires these services. OB4 currently works as a cashier, but her husband is unemployed. Online education exacerbated their financial

condition. They needed to set aside additional funds to purchase electricity tokens and internet quotas.

It's not fair that because we don't have enough money, my daughter can't study. We didn't know what coursework she had to do because her teacher shared it in a WhatsApp group for parents and we didn't always have enough internet, so we didn't receive it. By having a home visit, my daughter could study directly with teacher without the need for technology. (OB4/Parent/Interview)

3.8.4. Home visit programs overcame problems involved with teachers struggling to conduct online learning

GB2 stated that she had to undertake a substantial amount of catch-up work to utilize the technology in her classroom. Thanks to the home visit program, she recovered her teaching confidence. "I'm happier teaching in person, where I can see my students' smiles and laughs, even if it's not the whole class. No wires, no screen, just me and my students." (GB2/Teacher/Interview). The same sentiment was expressed by GB1, "I'm happy that there is an alternative method of teaching during a pandemic outbreak, such as a home visit program. It is a huge benefit for teachers who struggle with technology." (GB 1/Teacher/Interview).

3.8.5. A home visit program was a good alternative for parents who struggled with using gadgets

Also mentioned by the parents was the difficulty of using technology. They viewed the home visit program as a means for their children to continue learning without the need for access to or knowledge of technology. "I'm a stay-at-home mom. Except for making calls, I rarely use my cell phone. I have never used WhatsApp before. There's no doubt that the home visit program helps kids learn more. It's a step up." (OA1/Parent/Interview). Even for OB3, a highly educated mother who graduated from university and now works as a government official, utilizing a device is challenging.

Yes, I do use a gadget, however, I am restricted to its basic functions. The teacher has recently requested that we install a particular application. My mind was quickly lost. A home visit is preferable. No fancy technology is required for them to study. (OB3/Parent/Interview)

3.9. The disadvantages of the home visit program

3.9.1. Some parents felt obligated to entertain their children's teachers and peers

Even though it is not written in the rules that they must serve snacks and beverages for the teacher and the other students, they do so out of a form of duty to their community's custom of treating guests with respect. OB6 stated, "When my daughter had a home visit program, I didn't mind making food and drinks. But I felt pressured by myself to do so. I don't always have time to make it, and money was limited during the pandemic." (OB6/Parent/Interview). Another mom, OB5, a stay-at-home mother, indicated that she would thoroughly clean the home before the home visit program and prepare refreshments. "Well, I didn't want the teacher and parents to think badly of me, so I cleaned the house entirely and ensured they had enough food and drinks." (OB5/Parent/Interview).

3.9.2. Parents were exhausted since they had to teach and assist their children with their homework

Following the home visit, the teacher provided students with assignments to complete at home. Not every parent was pleased with the homework. Even though their office was closed during the lockdown, OB3, a government official, worked from home. She stated that she was drained from having to teach her children while working. "This is, I suppose, beyond my powers. I could hardly breathe. I have a job, must do housekeeping, and am now also teaching my children. Teaching is

challenging. We've missed so many assignments." (OB3/Parent/Interview). Even for a mother who is a teacher, like OB6, helping her children learn at home was not a simple task.

I have been teaching in the high school for almost 10 years. Now, my classes are online. But I should also teach my little ones. Well, it is only kindergarten, but she has many things to do, home visits, and these assignments. This may be the best for now, but not ideal. (OB6/Parent/Interview)

3.9.3. Some students could not study because the home visit location was too far away

The teacher arranged the home visit in one child's house and made a judgement regarding how easy it was to reach for all children. Nevertheless, the location of the house was too far away from OB3. She should ride a motorbike to drop her son at the house of the home visit program. When she met online for her office work, it became impossible. Then her son was not able to go to the home visit schooling.

I know that the teacher tried to choose a place that would be good for everyone. But our home is still far from where the home visit program takes place. I could only take him when I didn't have any work to complete or an online meeting to go to. He missed some of the home visit programs because I couldn't drive him there. (OB3/Parent/Interview)

3.9.4. The teachers needed to spend more time on media preparation and learning activities

Teachers were required to produce additional instructional materials and homework assignments for students. Since learning happened during the home visit program, teachers were required to carefully plan what materials they would bring and use throughout the program. They adhered to the semester program and weekly learning schedule. Some existing media should be remade because the available media was too large to transport to the home visit site. The home visit was scheduled for less than two hours, but achieving the desired learning outcomes took a lot of work. Therefore, they should have planned activities that children could complete independently or with their parents on the other days. GB4 explained, "I must prepare the learning materials, the activities for a visit, and the homework following the visit. I was busier than usual. A home visit needs a lot of extra preparation." (GB4/Teacher/Interview/Observation).

3.9.5. More time and energy were spent on having a home visit program

Due to the design of the home visit program, teaching and learning activities required additional time and effort from teachers and students. They should travel, which demands a 30 min to an hour motorcycle trip. Teachers should spend time with children and assist in educational activities. GA2 claimed, "It wasn't easy to set up a home visit program because we had to travel to meet the children. I should do it myself, which would cost money for gas and energy." (GA2/Teacher/Interview). On the one hand, parents could take a break from teaching their children, but on the other, they would need to prepare their children, drop them off at the home visit location, or prepare their home if it became the home visit location. "Well, I don't have to teach on that day, but I do need to get my son ready for the home visit program. But everyone wins." (OB3/Parent/Interview).

3.9.6. The risk of exposure to COVID-19 was increased

Teachers and parents stated that they were aware of the increased risks associated with their children and themselves attending class in person through the home visit program during the pandemic social restriction. GA2 said that she was so scared to conduct a home visit program. She was considerate of herself, her family, her pupils, and their families. She thought visiting someone else's home during the pandemic nightmare was unsafe. She might catch COVID-19 during their

encounter or on the trips. “Sure, I was scared. I wore a double mask and put a face shield also. It was during the time that so many people died because of COVID-19. We put ourselves at high risk.” (GA2/Teacher/Interview). Parents were concerned since it was difficult to tell young children to do or not do certain things. They might be unable to adhere to the government-mandated precautions against contracting the COVID-19 virus.

Even when I reminded my son to put on a face mask, he never did. So, I sent him to the site of the home visit program, even though I knew it was unsafe because he wouldn't be wearing a mask and could get COVID-19. It was scary at first, but we soon grew used to it. (OB3/Parent/Interview)

4. Discussion

A home visit program is one option to keep young children engaged in education during a pandemic school closure. The arrangement described by teachers in this study is comparable to similar programs implemented in numerous Indonesian kindergartens (Arzaqi et al., 2022; Nirmala & Annuar, 2020; Putra, 2020). The primary objective of these home visits during a pandemic in Indonesia is to substitute in-class teaching and learning activities, ensuring that children continue their education despite school closures.

While home visit programs in other countries are often used to prevent child abuse and neglect or to assess and offer care for children's physical and mental health (Honda, Yoshioka-Maeda, & Iwasaki-Motegi, 2020; Traube, Molina, YingWangKay, & Kemner, 2021; Williams, Ruiz, Hernandez, & Hancock, 2021), in Indonesia, the focus is on ensuring the continuity of education. This approach highlights the unique needs and priorities of Indonesian families during the pandemic. The program emerged organically to cater to the demands of parents and children who wanted consistent learning experiences with their teachers. During the peak of the COVID-19 pandemic, this initiative provided much-needed relief to parents who were overwhelmed with work, domestic tasks, and child-rearing responsibilities (Mastoah & MS, 2020; Wahad & Kahar, 2021).

However, the program was not without risks. Safety measures were not fully implemented, making it difficult to ensure young children wore masks and maintained social distance (Howard et al., 2020, 2021). Additionally, anti-COVID-19 vaccines were not available for children under 12 years old (Omer et al., 2021). Although children may not be highly susceptible to COVID-19 due to their robust immune systems, they could still be carriers of the virus (Yonker et al., 2020). The lack of school or government oversight on home visits further contributed to the risks associated with home-based group learning. Furthermore, during breaks in the home visit program, parents often provided food, increasing the potential for virus transmission during meals (Shen et al., 2021). These concerns underscore the need for better safety protocols in alternative education programs.

The home visit programs had both advantages and disadvantages. With this knowledge, it is crucial to minimize the negative aspects and enhance the positive aspects of these programs. Teaching young children requires skills and patience, and during school closures, parents had to take full responsibility for their children 24/7. The pandemic experience highlighted the necessity of better planning and management for future crises. The lack of digital gadgets and internet access in many households, the inability to teach online, and the nature of children's learning compelled kindergartens and teachers to adopt unprecedented methods.

Connecting to the global discourse, geospatial educational inequality and the digital divide are significant issues in Indonesia, similar to challenges faced globally. Studies have shown that the pandemic exacerbated these inequalities, making it essential to explore alternative educational models like home visits. However, these models must be refined to address safety and effectiveness. The findings of this study

align with global concerns about the digital divide and highlight the need for targeted interventions to support remote learning, particularly in underprivileged areas. This connection to global issues emphasizes the broader relevance and applicability of the study's findings.

Social science research and theory suggest that investing in early childhood education yields significant returns, especially for children from low-income families (Barnett & Nores, 2015; Esping-Andersen, 2013; Karoly, 2016). Investing in a child's early development may have far-reaching impacts, as cognitive and social-emotional development during infancy and early childhood is more susceptible to environmental stimuli (Mosier, 2013). Pre-academic skills, such as those fostered by early education programs, help children succeed in later academic endeavors (Eggum-Wilkens et al., 2014). Children participating in early childhood education programs are more likely to succeed in school, earn higher wages, and engage in less risky behaviors as adults (Campbell et al., 2014; Duncan & Magnuson, 2013). Therefore, investing in high-quality preschool programs can yield substantial returns (Denboba et al., 2014; Esping-Andersen, 2013). Abandoning children's education, even momentarily, jeopardizes their growth and causes learning loss. Impromptu remote emergency education is not a prudent practice.

Experts warned that forced remote education would result in substantial learning losses among the affected student population (Blaskó et al., 2022; Blundell et al., 2020; Hanushek & Woessmann, 2020). The home visit program in this study revealed that teachers, parents, and schools were unprepared, with no contingency plans in place. The significance and centrality of schools in children's lives underscore the urgency of preparing teachers and schools for emergencies. Despite the drawbacks of the home visit program in Indonesia, it remains promising to examine and improve it further to make it a better and safer education option for young children in situations with limited mobility, such as during a pandemic or after a natural disaster.

5. Conclusion

The study's findings have prompted a call for early childhood education institutions to be more prepared and have contingency plans for learning. Although most schools have reopened now, a sudden health hazard or other emergencies may occur at any time. For early childhood education, online learning is impracticable and challenging; well-planned and structured home visits may be effective, but other options should also be explored. During the pandemic, the procedure for a home visit program was to divide the class into small groups of children who live nearby, with teachers scheduling each group once or twice a week. The organization of the house visit may not be best; it would be preferable to conduct the home visit in a public learning space in the community. Typically, such open spaces exist in rural areas of Indonesia and are used for Posyandu, an integrated healthcare program for children and women. Future collaboration between schools, families, and communities should be improved, so that the facility can be utilized.

In urban densely crowded settings, home visit programs may not significantly reduce the risk of alleged viral infection; learning may be better managed in schools that divide students into small groups and have them attend school weekly, daily, or every few days. Thus, not all children come to school at the same time. Teachers should also be better prepared to handle the possibility of remote learning and to provide children with self-study modules or assignments to complete at home. Schools should maintain a repository of remote activities and tasks that can be substituted for in-class education when remote learning is implemented.

The COVID-19 epidemic has taught us that schools might indeed be closed for extended periods, up to two years, for most Indonesian schools. Due to the closure, many were concerned about the potential loss of education. Early childhood education should be centered on play and teaching children's values and life skills; hence, the activities prepared for children should not be burdensome for children and parents;

this is the most common criticism regarding learning during pandemics. The knowledge and skills of teaching in an emergency remote learning must be provided to pre-service teachers as part of their university education and to in-service teachers through specialized training in this subject.

One important area of inquiry that is absent from the paper is parents' and teachers' assessment of how well the visits worked for the children. The focus was primarily on the logistics and implementation of the program rather than its outcomes from these stakeholders' viewpoints. This is a crucial question in determining whether such programs could be revised and scaled up for other early childhood educational disruptions, such as natural disasters. Understanding the effectiveness from the perspectives of parents and teachers will provide valuable insights into the program's impact and feasibility, guiding future implementations.

This case study only observed one case from one kindergarten due to the social restriction policy in place at the time of the study, which prevented the researcher from investigating the case in other kindergartens that used home visits as a learning method during the COVID-19 remote learning period. The researcher recommends conducting investigations with a more extensive and diverse sample to understand this subject thoroughly. Further research should also include direct feedback from parents and teachers to evaluate the effectiveness of home visit programs comprehensively.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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